



NORTH KOREA

Capital city: Pyongyang
Area: 46,540 sq miles (120,540 sq km)
Population: 22,700,000
Official language: Korean
Major religion: No figures available
Government: One-party state
Currency: North Korean won
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 62 years
People per doctor: 333
Televisions: 53 per 1,000 people

NORTH KOREA

WITH ITS RUGGED, HILLY INTERIOR and limited fertile land, North Korea is a harsh country. Winds from central Asia produce extreme winter temperatures, and snow covers the ground for many months. Politically, North Korea is equally harsh. The communist government maintains a tight grip on its people. It limits contact with the outside world and forbids all foreign newspapers. Its health and education services have been badly affected by a lack of money, and many people face starvation every year. Recently there have been attempts to break the country's long isolation.



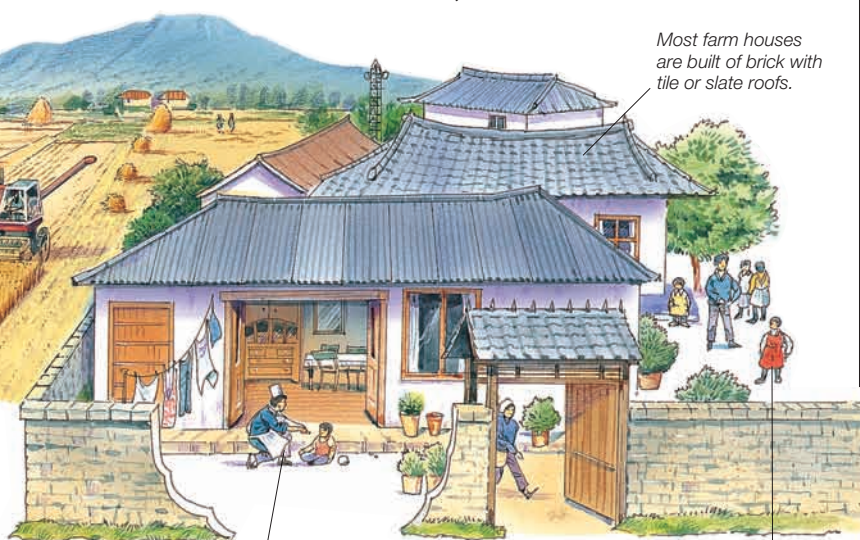
A DIVIDED LAND

At the end of World War II, Korea was occupied by Russian and American armies. In 1948, the country was divided in two. A communist government ruled the North and an American-backed, democratic government ruled the South. Today, the two sides face each other along one of the most heavily armed borders in the world.

Both men and women work on the land, growing rice, vegetables, grain, and fruit.

COLLECTIVE FARMING

Under the communist government, thousands of small, family-owned farms were abolished, replaced by 3,800 enormous state-controlled farms. These collective farms are run by people who work together to produce enough food to supply the country's needs. Because North Korea is so mountainous, every piece of available land is farmed intensively, with irrigation (watering) systems, advanced machinery, and fertilizers used to improve the annual harvest.



Health services are free for everyone, with doctors and nurses employed on each collective farm.

Every farm has its own day-care center and nursery school for babies and young children whose parents work on the land.

KOREAN FOOD

In North and South Korea, a whole meal is served at once, rather than in separate courses. Rice is always the main dish, often combined with barley and red beans and eaten with a range of spicy vegetables, herbs, and meats. Steamed rice cakes are prepared for important celebrations.

Kimchi, made from pickled cabbage and radishes mixed with garlic, salt, red pepper, and other spices, is a popular dish.



In jeolme, a type of rice cake powdered with soy flour, is served as a dessert.



Ginseng is exported around the world.

GINSENG

The root of the ginseng plant is grown in both North and South Korea. It is believed to promote good health and energy. After being washed, steamed, and dried, it can be ground into pills or made into lotion.



KIM IL SUNG

Kim Il Sung, dominated North Korea from 1948 until his death in 1994. He established an image as the father of working people. His portrait was hung in every office and huge statues were erected to him in public places. Under his rule, North Korea became increasingly isolated politically and economically from the rest of the world. He was succeeded by his son, Kim Jong Il, but is still referred to as the "eternal president."

Find out more

FARM "SHARING": 115, 140, 150
HEALTH, EDUCATION: 276, 277
IRRIGATION: 155, 156, 217
POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270-271